

What is Trauma?

Psychological trauma results from an event, series of events, or set of circumstances experienced **as physically or emotionally harmful** and that has **lasting negative effects** on the person's mental, physical, social, emotional, or spiritual well-being.



Dental Care and Trauma Responses

Recommendations for Positive Dental Experiences



What are Trauma Responses?

People who have gone through trauma sometimes respond to feelings of threat and danger based on **what happened** during the trauma, or **what might stop it from happening again**. Trauma responses can be **automatic and not intentional**. Trauma responses can include:

- Fight: expressing irritation or dissatisfaction.
- Flight: wanting to leave, getting up and leaving.
- Freeze: not moving, not talking.
- Fawn: being too compliant, not expressing needs.

Why does Trauma come up in Dental Care?

Some people who have lived through trauma find dental care uncomfortable. They report that things like **pain, closeness to another person, vulnerability, powerlessness, or physical restraint** can remind them of traumatic events.

Since it's stressful, can I just skip going to the dentist?

Regular dental care is critical to your oral health. Problems like pain, decay, and tooth loss can have a deep impact on things like socializing, eating with family, getting a good night's sleep, and living free of pain.



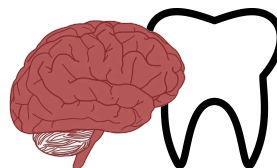
What are some resources for learning more or getting help?

- The **988 Lifeline** is a free, confidential talk line available 24/7, 365 days a year. Whether you're facing mental health struggles, emotional distress, alcohol or drug use concerns, or just need someone to talk to, the Lifeline is available.
 - You can call 988
 - You can also text or chat
 - Visit <https://988lifeline.org/>
- The **Oral Health Recovery Collaborative** website contains trauma-informed dental care resources and information at https://nschuman28.github.io/dental_care_project/index.html
- The **American Psychological Association** website has resources on coping with traumatic events, depression, anger, anxiety, PTSD, and addiction at <https://www.apa.org/topics/trauma/healing-guide>

Are you losing sleep or self or self medicating because of dental pain? Do you feel that your smile is affecting your employability or self esteem?

You're not alone. These strategies can help make dental care more possible for people with trauma:

- If you are avoiding dental care due to trauma, talk to a friend, peer, or healthcare professional about it. They might have some good ideas!
- Prepare for your dental appointment: make a list of things to talk about, decide how much you want to say, write down questions you might forget.
- Contact the dental clinic and ask questions you feel are important prior to scheduling an appointment.
- Ask your dental provider what they do to help people who are anxious.
- Before a dental procedure starts, tell your dental provider about your typical reactions and what other providers have done to help.



Should I tell my dental provider about my trauma history?

It depends. Some find it helpful to tell their dental provider, because then the provider will better understand their feelings and reactions. Others choose to keep the details private but still explain what their needs are. It's always up to you how much detail you give. Here are some examples:

- "I have had traumatic experiences with abuse and assault. That makes dental care more stressful for me."
- "I don't want to get into a lot of detail, but there are things in my past that make dental care really hard for me."
- "It's hard for me to trust others. It's hard for me to be here."

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